THE MAKING OF A COMPLICATED HAREM

When the city of Agra had been rebuilt by Akbar, and he went to live there, Monserrate wrote that ‘he found the place overrun with ghosts, which rushed to and fro, tore everything to pieces, terrified the women and children, threw stones, and finally began to hurt everyone there’. The ghouls may have been tolerated, we are told, if the matter had stopped there. ‘But the cruel spite of the Evil One began to wreak itself on the children of the King who were slain a day or two after birth.’ Akbar was twenty-seven years old now and found to his dismay that his children kept dying. The people of Agra had begun muttering darkly about malevolent spirits and evil forces, so when Harkha Bai became pregnant in 1569, Akbar decided to beg for divine intervention. Not far from Agra, on an isolated hillside, in a small town called Sikri, with wheeling kites and soft-stepping leopards for company, lived a Sufi pir, Salimuddin Chishti. Shaikh Salim lived a life as frugal as his surroundings, wearing a single layer of thin cotton clothes even in winter and keeping fasts during which he would eat only half a watermelon. Shaikh Salim promised the Padshah a son and Akbar immediately had Harkha Bai shifted to Sikri and built a palace for her near the khanqah of the shaikh. On 31 August 1569, a son was born to Harkha Bai. Dressed in a flowing black jama, Shaikh Ibrahim, Salim Chishti’s son-in-law, conveyed the news to the Padshah in Agra. Akbar named the child Salim, in honour of the shaikh. To further declare his allegiance to the Hindustani order of Sufis, the Chishtis, Akbar appointed a number of women from Shaikh Salim’s family to the prestigious post of milk mother to the infant.

When Salim was born, Akbar did not immediately visit the child, in deference to local customs. As recorded by Abu’l Fazl, ‘as the common people of this country have an old custom according to which whenever God, after long expectation, has bestowed an auspicious child, he be not produced before the honoured father till after a long delay’. The celebrations to mark this longed-for birth, however, were unprecedented both around the mother in Sikri and at the court in Agra. The entire darbar was caught up in a frenzy of excitement. Both Greek and Hindu horoscopes